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Website <https://u3aepsom.nz/>.

MEETING PLACE

Royal Oak Bowls, 146 Selwyn St, Onehunga

10am on the 2ND Thursday of most months

NEWSLETTER

October 2026

Next meeting

10-12noon

Thursday, 8 October 2026

There's lots to do in our neck of the woods over the next few weeks: Cornwall Park is hosting a Heritage Food Festival from the 3rd to the 11th of October. They're also advertising their guided Spring walks. I've been on a couple - they are really very good. To book a place, go to their website.

The Armageddon Expo is on at the Auckland Showgrounds in Greenlane Rd from the 23rd to the 26th. This is the one where everyone dresses up as a superhero or a Star Wars character or just something weird. The outdoor events are free and, if you want a free show, this is the place for you.

The Diwali Festival is free in Aotea Square on October 31 and November 1st.

The Auckland Heritage Festival continues until the 11th. It's a good time to be out and about.

The new CRL is also worth a look. I'm not sure it justifies the cost but it makes getting pretty much anywhere in the central city very easy from, say, Onehunga, Ellerslie or Greenlane.

Best thoughts to Duncan and Julie MacDonald. At the time of writing, Duncan is in the surgical ward at Auckland Hospital after breaking his hip and suffering a stroke. I'm sure we all wish him well.

Ian

EPSOM U3A EXECUTIVE

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Jenny Whatman – 027 353 2487

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Kaye Buchanan- 021 299 0709

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Charmaine Strang – 027 4177 556

Interest Group Co-ordinators

Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680

Bill Hagan – 021 611 247

Guest Speaker Organiser:

Ian Jost – 027 488 7037

Legal Advisor

Mike Matson – 022 630 7968

Newsletter

Jeanette Grant – 638 8566

Greeters:

Don Buchanan 0275 928 131

Helen Dallaston - 022-2647786

INTEREST GROUP CONVENERS

Applied Sciences

Peter Parsons - 021 521446

Attending Performing Arts

Shirin Caldwell – 630 1662

Architecture

Brian Murray – 021 026 68396

Art Appreciation

Kaye Buchanan – 021 299 0709

Art History

Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094

Big History

Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094

Book Chat

Helen Holdem - 021 260 3510

Chess Group

John Locke - 021-187 8061

Comparative Religions

Duncan MacDonald - 021-316 661

John Locke- 021-187 8061

Current Affairs

Shirley McConville – 622 3542

Fabric & Fibre Crafts

Charmaine Strang – 027-4177 556

Famous & Infamous Group

Shirley McConville – 622 3542

Foodies

Graham Gunn – 027 445 0929.

Garden Appreciation

Betty Townley - 626 6673

Introduction to Family History

Bryn Smith – 027 280 5235

Latin

Phyllis Downes – 630 5867

Lunch Bunch

Shirley McConville – 622 3542.

Music Appreciation

Carleen Edwards – 624 6298

History & Social Change

Helen Holdem – 021 260 3510

NZ History

Kaye Buchanan - 021 299 0709

Philosophy

Jocelyn Hewin - 634-1552

Scrabble

Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680

Stories of the Past

Jeanette Grant – 638 8566

Te Reo Maori

Jenny Whatman – 027 353 2487

Travel

Diana Hart- 021 284 4402

SPEAKER REPORT

Our September speaker, Janine Nillesen, shared her enthusiasm and commitment, in an engaging talk about her work as a park ranger over the last 25 years at Ambury farm. She has also been a driving force and co-chair of the Friends of the Farm, a Mangere Bridge local community group which supports zero-waste initiatives, practical working bees and neighbourhood events. Their mission is to create a caring, connected wastewise community.

Janine talked about her passion for local zero waste initiatives, and cleaning up the mangroves and the foreshore along the Esplanade, which has allowed birds to re-establish their breeding and roosting grounds.

The land at Ambury Farm was formed by volcanic action 70,000 years ago, so has rich fertile volcanic soil and the nearby abundant fishing grounds in the Manukau Harbour supported a substantial Maori population in pre-European times.

In the 1880's, a farm was established and by the 1940's, this was known as Point farm. The land supported a co-operative dairy company and even today, cows are milked for six months of the year. In the 1960s Watercare developed the sewage ponds for a growing city, this leading to pollution and degradation of the harbour, until modern systems were later built.

In 1977, after much local lobbying to prevent the farm being used for industrial development, Ambury Farm was turned into a regional park of 210 acres, and is now supported financially by the Auckland Council.

Currently, sheep, turkeys, pigs, horses, cattle, chickens and llamas can be found on the farm, the llamas proving to be excellent guards for scaring away pesky dogs. There is a riding school and pony club, an education centre, a campground with 60 spaces, the facilities being well-used by the public, schools, scout groups and tourists. Volleyball is played there in the weekends. The farm is a great way to introduce city children to where their food comes from and they can attend animal feeding sessions. Over-popularity has been a problem which has now led to some limits on farm days and lamb feeding.

Most of the work is done by volunteers (987.5 hours by 30 main volunteers last year) who help with rat-trapping and pest control, cleaning, animal care, pruning and planting, mangrove seed removal, and participating in the many events co-ordinated by Friends of the Farm.

eg A repair café at Mangere library once per month, working in the community orchard, running gardening and pruning workshops, arranging for a pumpkin growing competition, helping with a lantern moonlight walk for Matariki (to which 550 people came this year), doing foreshore, village and park clean-ups on designated days, managing the recycling programmes (for blister packs, razor blades and toothpaste tubes).

Puketutu Island and Hamelins Hill are also looked after by the Ambury team, and there are four full-time paid staff. They are currently lobbying council and government for change in NZ's recycling schemes. The tremendous commitment of volunteers is honoured with a celebration event each year. Janine Nillesen received a well-deserved Lifetime Contribution Award at the 2026 Tāmaki Makaurau Zero Waste Awards, to acknowledge her long-standing valuable environmental and community work.

Ambury Farm is an asset to our city and is well worth a visit. The area is delightful for walking, bird-watching and introducing your grandchildren to the natural environment.

By Joslyn Squire

REQUEST

We have had a request from Ann Hood (annhood55@gmail.com) who is a member of the u3a Parnell Branch. She has been asked to establish conversation groups for small groups of asylum seeker women and is looking for volunteers who may be able to assist. These groups will run during school terms for 1.5 hours a week and while previous experience would be helpful it is definitely not required. Full details of what is involved are attached to this October newsletter

OCTOBER MAIN SPEAKER	Our speaker in October will be Dr David Addis. Some members might remember David from last year when he stepped in at the last minute when our scheduled speaker caught Covid and had to pull out. He then spoke of his experiences in Nepal when he was a newly-qualified GP. This month, he will speak about the need for iodine in the body. But don't think this is just a medical lecture - it's much more than that. David will outline how scientists and doctors first came to suspect that people were sickening because of a lack of iodine, and how they worked out that the population of mountainous regions contracted more goitre than other areas, then tried to understand why; and so on. It's a bit like a detective story. This is a good talk. I've heard it once at the Applied Science interest group but I thought it was so good I've asked David to tell it to the main meeting. Apologies to those who've heard it before but it's worthwhile hearing it again. – Ian
INTEREST GROUPS	[1] There is keen interest in a Literature group and lists will be put out at the October and November meetings. A series of DVD's about stories of significance will be shown, followed by discussion about members' reading. The Deaf Centre is confirmed as the venue, on Thursdays in week 4 of each month. Joslyn will talk at the next main meeting, about the new literature interest group. [2] The Garden Appreciation Group is in danger of folding if no-one is prepared to take over the role of Convenor by the end of the year. This is not arduous but is essential for keeping the group in contact. Talk to Bill Hagan if you can help. [3] Doug Crutch has offered to host a series of talks on AI, and tentatively convene an interest group if there is interest.
2026 MEETING DATES Thursdays, 10am	8 October 12 November AGM NB Always wear your name badge and be seated ready at 10am

**THOUGHT
FOR THE
MONTH**

**IN WINE
THERE IS WISDOM,
IN BEER
THERE IS FREEDOM,
IN WATER
THERE IS BACTERIA.**

ACOUSTIC KITTY

During the Cold War, the CIA explored some of the strangest spy ideas ever put on paper. Declassified documents describe birds trained to deliver listening devices, pigeons carrying tiny cameras over Soviet targets, and dolphins tested for missions against enemy ships. The wildest case may be Acoustic Kitty: a cat reportedly fitted with surveillance equipment so it could listen in on sensitive conversations. The programs reveal a brutal mix of paranoia, genius, waste, animal suffering, and spy-agency arrogance pushed to absurd limits.

LANDLESS STATE

What if a country had no land at all, yet was still recognized around the world? The Sovereign Military Order of Malta operates with its own passports, government, and diplomatic relations, despite having zero official territory. With only three official citizens and recognition from over 100 countries, it functions like a real state in almost every way. It's one of the strangest geopolitical anomalies on Earth — a country that exists, even though it's technically nowhere.

LUNAR LANDERS

Africa could place its first scientific instruments on the moon in 2029 through the Africa2Moon initiative, a project selected as an international payload for China's Chang'e-8 mission. The mission's Bounced African Low Lunar Sphere (BALLS) probes are designed to create a small lunar radio astronomy array near the moon's south pole.

The three spherical probes will serve as a technology demonstrator, testing methods for future lunar science missions. Their main objective is to study low-frequency radio signals from distant and ancient parts of the universe, signals that cannot be properly observed from Earth because of atmospheric effects and radio interference.

The BALLS mission is built around a simple idea: use the quiet environment of the moon to explore parts of the universe that remain difficult to study from Earth. According to Carla Mitchell, mission director of Africa2Moon and Africa Program manager at SARAO, the lunar surface offers a unique location for detecting low-frequency radio waves that are blocked or distorted by Earth's environment.

BIBLICAL DOS AND DON'TS

According to the Old Testament, if a burglar breaks into a house at night then the homeowner can use lethal force. However if the same offense is committed during the day, the incumbent is forbidden to draw blood in self-defence. Exodus 22:2-3 reads: *"If a thief is caught breaking in at night and is struck a fatal blow, the defender is not guilty of bloodshed; but if it happens after sunrise, the defender is guilty of bloodshed."*

Hitting below the belt is not allowed in boxing and it turns out, the Bible also condemns it. When a man is fighting another man, no wife is allowed to grab her husband's enemy's private parts... The punishment? They get their hands chopped off. Deuteronomy 25:11-12 reads: *"When men strive together one with another, and the wife of the one draweth near for to deliver her husband out of the hand of him that smiteth him, and putteth forth her hand, and taketh him by the secrets: Then thou shalt cut off her hand, thine eye shall not pity her."*

Tearing up clothes was a sign of grieving and mourning in biblical times, but Moses imparted some advice regarding this action. Leviticus 10:6 reads: *"And Moses said unto Aaron, and unto Eleazar and unto Ithamar, his sons, Uncover not your heads, neither rend your clothes; lest ye die, and lest wrath come upon all the people: but let your brethren, the whole house of Israel, bewail the burning which the Lord hath kindled."*

MARTIAN ATMOSPHERE DISAPPEARING

Unlike Earth, Mars lacks a strong global magnetic field capable of shielding its atmosphere from the constant stream of charged particles flowing outward from the Sun. This leaves the planet's upper atmosphere directly exposed to the solar wind, allowing complex interactions to occur where space and atmosphere meet. Researchers now show that this interaction resembles wind blowing across the surface of an ocean. Instead of producing water waves, the solar wind generates enormous plasma disturbances known as Kelvin–Helmholtz waves, which develop along the atmospheric boundary.

These waves create large clouds of ionized gas that make it easier for atmospheric particles to escape the planet's gravity. Scientists had proposed several possible mechanisms for producing these plasma clouds over the years, yet direct observational proof remained elusive. That changed when researchers combined observations from NASA's MAVEN spacecraft with data from China's Tianwen-1 mission. While Tianwen-1 monitored the incoming solar wind upstream of Mars, MAVEN simultaneously measured atmospheric ions escaping near the planet. The dual-spacecraft observations allowed scientists to connect changes in the solar wind directly to bursts of atmospheric escape, providing evidence that the giant plasma waves are responsible for much of this enhanced ion loss.

NEW YORK CITY ENDANGERED?

A 96-story skyscraper in one of New York's ultra wealthy neighbourhoods is feared to be cracking apart as it terrifyingly sways in high winds, engulfing its tenants in a bitter legal battle with the builders, who they accused of covering up critical flaws. The city maintains it is safe.

Meanwhile, another 60-story high-rise overlooking the city's financial nerve center sits half-finished as it sinks into the ground and leans more and more to one side. The leaning tower has sparked its own lawsuit as its builders say the skyscraper is too dangerous to finish and blame the project's developers for choosing cheap shortcuts which led to the potentially catastrophe issue.

While New York City officials said everything safe for now, it may only be a matter of time before some of the city's largest buildings trigger more mass evacuation orders like the crumbling albatross now sitting on 42nd Street. The 'supertall' residential tower on New York City's Billionaires' Row has seen a long list of issues documented since it opened in 2015. Soon after residents started moving in, condo owners began complaining about alarming swaying and creaking noises in the wind, plus cracks in walls, ceilings and the building's concrete facade.

Former celebrity power couple Jennifer Lopez and Alex Rodriguez once lived in the exclusive high-rise in 2018, but quickly moved out of their \$15.3 million condo one year later. The now-separated couple cited a lack of space for selling. It is not known if they encountered similar issues while living in the building. Eventually, inspections of 432 Park discovered 'thousands of severe cracks,' including a 10-inch-deep crack in the building's core. 'Other forms of deterioration' were also reported by independent building engineers. According to a lawsuit filed in 2021 by the condo board against the building's developers and a follow-up lawsuit in 2025, these problems have persisted for years, and other tenants claimed the developers knew about the defects before residents moved in.

For the full story – see <https://www.msn.com/en-nz/lifestyle/other/report-two-nyc-skyscrapers-feared-at-risk-after-high-rise-collapse/ar-AA29jKuv>

SOLAR PANEL

Iris' new solar generator has a handy feature you don't often see on units like these: the ability to follow the sun around the sky. The Iris T1 has a 32-W solar panel that can rotate on two axes to track the sun and capture more rays through the day. The company says this makes for performance gains of up to 40% compared to fixed panels.

That panel sits atop a compact round device with detachable legs that holds a 270-Wh battery and USB ports for power output. That's unlike most other popular generators from the likes of Anker and Ecoflow, which require a separate panel to be carried and connected with cables. The entire system comes in at 10 lb (4.5 kg), and you can choose between a fixed or folding solar panel which attaches magnetically. That allows the T1 to be plenty portable. It can be set up in under a minute without a tangle of wires to trip over. This unit comes with a removable and replaceable 270-Wh battery, which can be fully charged using the panel in about 8-10 hours on a clear day. That's good for up to 20 full charges of an iPhone 15, or topping off a 13-inch MacBook Pro two to three times. If you're rocking a Starlink Mini antenna, that'll run for four to six hours...

Iris is currently crowdfunding the T1 on Kickstarter, where it can be ordered for as little as US\$1,120 (down from its expected MSRP of \$1,495). This includes a 270-Wh battery. An extra battery will cost you \$285, while a 99-Wh battery goes for \$185.

Source: Kickstarter

TREASURE SHIP FOUND AFTER NEARLY 400 YEARS

A royal ship carrying millions in sunken treasure has been found in a Scottish river after sinking 400 years ago. The 'Blessing of Burntisland' capsized in a storm while crossing the Firth of Forth from Fife to Leith as part of King Charles I's coronation tour in July 1633. On board was a consignment of silver and gold worth an estimated £100,000 at the time, equivalent to around £20million in today's money. All but two of the ship's 35 passengers and crew were drowned, and its precious cargo vanished without a trace.

The 'Blessing of Burntisland' was a wooden ferry built in the early 1600s to carry people and cargo across the Firth of Forth, in Scotland. The ferry made the five-mile (eight km) journey from Burntisland to Leith. In 1633, the Blessing was loaded with 20 carts of jewels, plates, and textiles belonging to King Charles I. He had been undertaking an official tour of Scotland after his coronation there, and was now travelling southwards toward Leith.

Due to the depth of the wreck and the shifting, silty water of the Firth of Forth, the 'Blessing of Burntisland' has long been thought lost for good. But thanks to advances in modern technology, a group of investigators think they have finally found the long-lost wreck alongside its precious payload. Experts from the Charles Wrex Project, led by Burntisland Heritage, have released a report claiming that the wreck may have been found just one mile outside the town. The report claims that the project has '*now located what is believed to be the wreck of the Blessing, and work to retrieve items from the wreck is imminent*'. If the ship and its cargo are recovered, the Crown would be the official owner, with Burntisland Heritage standing as 'salvor in possession'.